



Coneys,
or rabbits

Wood
pigeons

Goose

STAGING A SLAUGHTER

In 1693, John Dowdall, a visitor to Stratford, was told that Shakespeare had worked as a butcher. Soon after this, writer John Aubrey recorded the same story, adding that when William killed a calf, "He would do it in a high style, and make a speech."



GREEN FINGERS

Shakespeare's characters often refer to flowers and plants, sowing, pruning, weeding, and other gardening activities. This could mean that he worked as a gardener for a time, or simply that he took an interest in his own garden.



Spike to make
holes for
stitching

Half-
moon
leather
knife

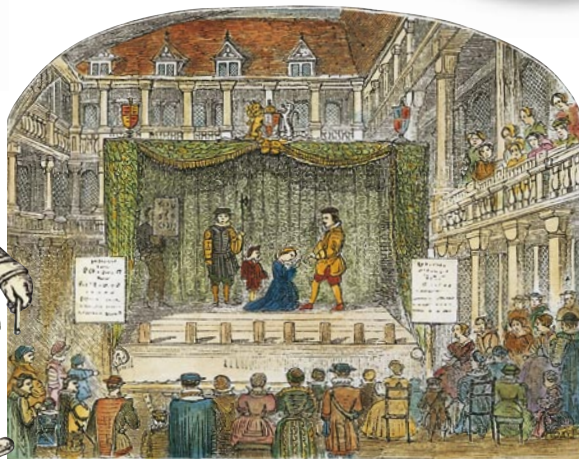
Hooked
leather
knife

LEATHER WORKING

Shakespeare is likely to have learned leather-working skills in his father's glove making workshop. After leaving school, with his family facing hard times, William may well have helped his father, using tools like these to make gloves, belts, or shoes.



16th-century engraving
of Richard Tarlton



TAKING TO THE STAGE

In the 1580s, several companies of actors visited Stratford, performing in the town's inn yards. England's leading company, the Queen's Men, performed in Stratford in 1587. Shakespeare would surely have seen the company, whose star was the clown Richard Tarlton. He even might have joined them. All we know for certain is that, at some point, William Shakespeare became a player, or actor.

Hand-colored engraving of
players performing in an inn yard

MILITARY INTELLIGENCE
In the 1800s, Shakespeare scholar W.J. Thoms argued that the playwright's military knowledge meant that he had served as a soldier. Thoms found a document naming a soldier called William Shakespeare. But this man was serving in 1605, when our Shakespeare was a famous and successful playwright.



MEDICINE MAN
Shakespeare's work shows that he had some knowledge of medicine, but his characters are often scornful of physicians, or doctors. Macbeth says, "Throw physic to the dogs," and Timon of Athens says, "Trust not the physician."



Elizabethan trenchers,
or plates, decorated
with paintings and
verses representing
professions



CASE CLOSED
Shakespeare's plays are full of legal terms. In 1790, English scholar Edmund Malone suggested that the playwright gained this knowledge working in a legal office. In fact, Shakespeare was involved in several legal cases, which may explain his understanding of the law.